PADHAKU
Footprints without Feet · Class 10 English

CHAPTER 4

A Question of Trust

NCERT Exercise Solutions

A Question of Trust · Before You Read 1 Q

A Question of Trust · Read and Find Out (1) 2 Q

A Question of Trust · Read and Find Out (2) 2 Q

A Question of Trust · Think about It 4 Q

A Question of Trust · Talk about It 2 Q

✨ Try each question yourself first, then check the answer. 💡 answers are samples: write your own.

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A Question of Trust · Before You Read

1 **It is said that you must set a thief to catch a thief. But it is also said that there is honour among thieves. Which saying does this story illustrate?**

✔ ANSWER

The story illustrates **"set a thief to catch a thief"**.

A clever young woman thief tricks Horace Danby, himself a thief, into opening the safe for her. Horace learns that there is **no 'honour among thieves'** – that is why he gets angry when anyone uses the phrase.

A Question of Trust · Read and Find Out (1)

1 **What does Horace Danby like to collect?**

✔ ANSWER

Horace Danby likes to collect **rare and expensive books**.

2 **Why does he steal every year?**

✔ ANSWER

He steals every year to get enough money to **buy the rare, expensive books** he loves. He steals enough to last twelve months and buys the books secretly through an agent.

? A Question of Trust · Read and Find Out (2)

1 **Who is speaking to Horace Danby?**

✔ ANSWER

A **young, pretty lady dressed in red** speaks to him. She pretends to be the lady of the house (the owner's wife), but she is really a clever thief.

2 **Who is the real culprit in the story?**

✔ ANSWER

The **young lady in red** is the real culprit. She tricks Horace into opening the safe with a false story and takes away the jewels herself. Horace, who opened the safe without gloves, is caught for her robbery.

🤔 A Question of Trust · Think about It

1 **Did you begin to suspect, before the end of the story, that the lady was not the person Horace Danby took her to be? If so, at what point did you realise this, and how?**

💡 SAMPLE ANSWER

Yes, some doubts arise before the end.

- She says she **"didn't expect to meet a burglar"** but is calm and even amused instead of frightened.
- She says, **"I have always liked the wrong kind of people."**
- The lady of the house would know the numbers of her own safe, but she claims she has **forgotten them** and happily lets Horace **break the safe**.
- She does not call the police though she said, "Society must be protected from men like you."

The truth is clear at the end, when the real wife turns out to be a gray-haired woman of sixty.

2 **What are the subtle ways in which the lady manages to deceive Horace Danby into thinking she is the lady of the house? Why doesn't Horace suspect that something is wrong?**

✔ ANSWER

Her tricks:

- She knows the dog's name, and **Sherry rubs against her**; she says, "Down, Sherry... Anyone would think I'd been away for a month!"
- She **straightens the ornaments** on the fireplace as if it is her own home.
- She speaks with quiet firmness and threatens to **telephone the police**.
- She takes a cigarette from the silver box and tells a believable story: she promised her husband to take her jewels to the bank, left them in the safe, wants to wear them to a party, and has forgotten the numbers.

Why Horace doesn't suspect: he is frightened of going to prison and **desperate to be let off**. He is eager to please her, so he believes her story without thinking. His hay fever also troubles him.

3 **"Horace Danby was good and respectable — but not completely honest". Why do you think this description is apt for Horace? Why can't he be categorised as a typical thief?**

✔ ANSWER

Apt description: Horace was a respected locksmith, about fifty, with a successful business and two helpers. People thought him a good, honest citizen. But he robbed **one safe every year**, so he was not completely honest.

Not a typical thief:

- He stole only to buy **rare, expensive books**, not for luxury.
- He took only enough for one year and stole **only from people who have a lot of money**.
- He planned carefully, used no violence, was kind to the dog and admitted he was only trying to frighten the lady.

So he is a gentle, careful and educated thief, not a common criminal.

4 **Horace Danby was a meticulous planner but still he faltered. Where did he go wrong and why?**

✔ ANSWER

Horace studied Shotover Grange for two weeks – its rooms, wiring, paths and garden – and always wore gloves to avoid fingerprints. Yet he went wrong:

- He did not plan for the **bowl of flowers** that set off his hay fever; his sneezing gave him away.
- He trusted the young lady **without checking** who she was.
- In his eagerness to please her he **took off his gloves** to give her his lighter and then opened the safe without them, leaving **fingerprints all over the room**.

He faltered because **fear of prison** and his wish to be let off made him careless. A cleverer thief used his weakness and he was arrested for her robbery.

? A Question of Trust · Talk about It

1 Do you think Horace Danby was unfairly punished, or that he deserved what he got?

💡 SAMPLE ANSWER

Points for discussion:

- **Unfair:** he was punished for a robbery that the young lady really committed; he only opened the safe because she asked him.
- **Deserved:** he entered the house to rob the same safe; he had been robbing a safe every year and broke his promise after only two days by planning another robbery.

Model view: He deserved his punishment. He was not guilty of this exact theft, but he was a thief who went there to steal. As the saying goes, "As you sow, so shall you reap."

2 Do intentions justify actions? Would you, like Horace Danby, do something wrong if you thought your ends justified the means? Do you think that there are situations in which it is excusable to act less than honestly?

💡 SAMPLE ANSWER

Points for discussion:

- Good intentions **do not justify wrong actions**. Horace's love of books cannot excuse stealing; wrong means spoil even a good end.
- I would not do something wrong for my goals. I would work hard and earn honestly.
- A few rare situations may be excusable, for example a small untruth to save someone's life, or keeping a surprise for a friend, as long as no one is harmed or cheated.
- In everyday life, **honesty is the best policy**; dishonesty usually leads to trouble, as it did for Horace.

🎉 **Chapter 4 done! Revise the answers once more tomorrow.**